Who Are We?

Social Identity Theory in Campus Life

How campus labels shape belonging and bias



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

第 6 组 | GROUP 6

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Which label comes first?

Think of one label you used in your first week on campus.

HOMETOWN	Local	Non-local
PERSONALITY	Introvert	Extrovert
CAMPUS LIFE	Major	Club



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

When does a label become a judgment?

Part of “I” comes from “we”

Group identities shape how we see ourselves and other people.

SOCIAL IDENTITY

The part of self-concept connected with valued group memberships.



Photo: Ludovic Delot / Pexels · illustrative

Labels support belonging. They can also narrow judgment.

Tajfel & Turner (1979); APA Dictionary of Psychology, “Social identity theory.”

Three mechanisms, one campus



Photo: Padmathilaka Wanigasekara / Pexels



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Categorization

Who is “us”?

A hometown accent

Identification

Where do I belong?

A running group

Comparison

How do “we” compare?

Our major vs. theirs

Connected mechanisms, not a fixed sequence. All campus cases are illustrative.

Tajfel & Turner (1979); social influence extension: Turner & Oakes (1986).

Categorization: a familiar accent



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

CAMPUS SCENARIO

“You sound like you’re from Xuzhou.”

“One of us”

Accent is a cue, not evidence of ability or character.

A useful social shortcut can hide individual differences.

Even small boundaries can matter

MINIMAL GROUP STUDY

GROUP LABELS

Relatively trivial group distinctions

DECISION

Distribution of rewards

FINDING

Favoritism toward the ingroup

A simple group boundary can influence reward decisions.

A tendency in a controlled setting; not a rule about every person or campus.

Tajfel et al. (1971). European Journal of Social Psychology. doi:10.1002/ejsp.2420010202

Identification: becoming “one of us”



Photo: Edmond Dantès / Pexels · illustrative

01 **TRY**

“I will go once.”

02 **BELONG**

“I am a runner.”

03 **PRACTICE**

“This is our routine.”

Valued group norms can become personal standards.

Social identity and social influence: Turner & Oakes (1986). Campus story: illustrative scenario.

Comparison: how good is “our” group?

HYPOTHETICAL CLAIM

“Our major is more practical than theirs.”

SELF-ENHANCEMENT

A favorable view of “us”



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Ask for evidence: better in what respect?

Tajfel & Turner (1979). Student claim is hypothetical; no major ranking is asserted.

Belonging has a boundary



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

WHAT IT CAN OFFER	WHAT IT CAN COST
Belonging	**Exclusion**
Encouragement	**Pressure to conform**
Shared purpose	**Stereotypes**

Value your community. Stay curious about people beyond it.

A label is a starting point



Photo: Yan Krukau / Pexels · illustrative

CONSIDER THE LABEL

“Quiet”

One behavior.
Many possible explanations.

A careful listener?
An experienced researcher?
Someone with an idea to share?

Ask about interests, experience, and opportunities to participate.

From English learner to English user

A LIMITING SELF-DESCRIPTION

“I am only a learner.”

A POSSIBILITY FOR PARTICIPATION

“I can contribute an idea.”



Photo: Ludovic Delot / Pexels · illustrative

Social relationships can shape opportunities to use English.

Vocabulary, practice, feedback, and support still matter.

Related research: Norton Peirce (1995). TESOL Quarterly. doi:10.2307/3587803

Three habits for a wider “we”

01

Notice the label

What do I actually know about this person?

02

Seek another connection

Which interests or goals might we share?

03

Make participation possible

Whose idea have we not yet invited?



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

Identity is also about “we”

Groups can shape belonging. Labels should not define the whole person.



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

CATEGORIZE

Organize the social world

IDENTIFY

Make membership meaningful

COMPARE

Position “us” in relation to others

Thank you.

Which campus label would you rethink?

What would you want to know about the person behind it?

QUESTIONS & IDEAS



Photo: George Pak / Pexels · illustrative

References / Theory and classic evidence

01 Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979). An integrative theory of intergroup conflict. In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The social psychology of intergroup relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole.

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04 Turner, J. C., & Oakes, P. J. (1986). The significance of the social identity concept for social psychology with reference to individualism, interactionism and social influence. British Journal of Social Psychology, 25(3), 237–252.

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